'Yes, but it does not; I am rancorous—the only stigma that proves me to be a churchman. Do you understand? You understand that you are in no way obliged to go with me.'

'Come, now,' said Athos, 'you are joking.'

'In that case, my dear friend, if you are resolved to accompany me there is no time to lose; the drum beats; I observed cannon on the road; I saw the citizens in order of battle on the Place of the Hôtel de Ville; certainly the fight will be in the direction of Charenton, as the Duc de Châtillon said.'

'I supposed,' said Athos, 'that last night's conferences would modify those warlike arrangements.'

'No doubt; but they will fight, none the less, if only to mask the conferences.'

'Poor creatures!' said Athos, 'who are going to be killed, in order that Monsieur de Bouillon may have his estate at Sedan restored to him, that the reversion of the admiralty may be given to the Duc de Beaufort, and that the coadjutor may be made a cardinal.'

'Come, come, dear Athos, confess that you would not be so philosophical if your Raoul were to be involved in this affair.'

'Perhaps you speak the truth, Aramis.'

'Well, let us go, then, where the fighting is, for that is the most likely place to meet with D'Artagnan, Porthos, and possibly even Raoul. Stop, there are a fine body of citizens passing; quite attractive, by Jupiter! and their captain—see! he has the true military style.'

'What, ho!' said Grimaud.

'What?' asked Athos.

'Planchet, sir.'

'Lieutenant yesterday,' said Aramis, 'captain to-day, colonel, doubtless, to-morrow; in a fortnight the fellow will be marshal of France.'

'Question him about the fight,' said Athos.

Planchet, prouder than ever of his new duties, deigned to explain to the two gentlemen that he was ordered to take up his position on the Place Royale with two hundred men, forming the rear of the army of Paris, and to march on Charenton when necessary.

'This day will be a warm one,' said Planchet, in a warlike tone.

'No doubt,' said Aramis, 'but it is far from here to the enemy.'

'Sir, the distance will be diminished,' said a subordinate.

Aramis saluted, then turning toward Athos:

'I don't care to camp on the Place Royale with all these people,' he said. 'Shall we go forward? We shall see better what is going on.'

'And then Monsieur de Châtillon will not come to the Place Royale to look for you. Come, then, my friend, we will go forward.'

'Haven't you something to say to Monsieur de Flamarens on your own account?'

'My friend,' said Athos, 'I have made a resolution never to draw my sword save when it is absolutely necessary.'

'And how long ago was that?'

'When I last drew my poniard.'

'Ah! Good! another souvenir of Monsieur Mordaunt. Well, my friend, nothing now is lacking except that you should feel remorse for having killed that fellow.'

'Hush!' said Athos, putting a finger on his lips, with the sad smile peculiar to him; 'let us talk no more of Mordaunt—it will bring bad luck.' And Athos set forward toward Charenton, followed closely by Aramis.

A light cloud passed over the count's face.

'Raoul gives me much uneasiness,' he said. 'He received yesterday a message from the Prince de Condé; he went to meet him at Saint Cloud and has not returned.'

'Have you seen Madame de Chevreuse?'

'She was not at home. And you, Aramis, you were going, I think, to visit Madame de Longueville.'

'I did go there.'

'Well?'

'She was no longer there, but she had left her new address.'

'Where was she?'

'Guess; I give you a thousand chances.'

'How should I know where the most beautiful and active of the Frondists was at midnight? for I presume it was when you left me that you went to visit her.'

'At the Hôtel de Ville, my dear fellow.'

'What! at the Hotel de Ville? Has she, then, been appointed provost of merchants?'

'No; but she has become queen of Paris, *ad interim*, and since she could not venture at once to establish herself in the Palais Royal or the Tuileries, she is installed at the Hôtel de Ville, where she is on the point of giving an heir or an heiress to that dear duke.'

'You didn't tell me of that, Aramis.'

'Really? It was my forgetfulness then; pardon me.'

'Now,' asked Athos, 'what are we to do with ourselves till evening? Here we are without occupation, it seems to me.'

'You forget, my friend, that we have work cut out for us in the direction of Charenton; I hope to see Monsieur de Châtillon, whom I've hated for a long time, there.'

'Why have you hated him?'

'Because he is the brother of Coligny.'

'Ah, true! he who presumed to be a rival of yours, for which he was severely punished; that ought to satisfy you.'

And they hastened to quit the palace, followed by Bazin, who was lavish of bows and compliments.

'Well,' said Athos, when Aramis and he were in the boat again, 'are you beginning to be convinced that we should have done a bad turn to all these people in arresting Mazarin?'

'You are wisdom incarnate, Athos,' Aramis replied.

What had especially been observed by the two friends was the little interest taken by the court of France in the terrible events which had occurred in England, which they thought should have arrested the attention of all Europe.

In fact, aside from a poor widow and a royal orphan who wept in the corner of the Louvre, no one appeared to be aware that Charles I had ever lived and that he had perished on the scaffold.

The two friends made an appointment for ten o'clock on the following day; for though the night was well advanced when they reached the door of the hotel, Aramis said that he had certain important visits to make and left Athos to enter alone.

At ten o'clock the next day they met again. Athos had been out since six o'clock.

'Well, have you any news?' Athos asked.

'Nothing. No one has seen D'Artagnan and Porthos has not appeared. Have you anything?'

'Nothing.'

'The devil!' said Aramis.

'In fact,' said Athos, 'this delay is not natural; they took the shortest route and should have arrived before we did.'

'Add to that D'Artagnan's rapidity in action and that he is not the man to lose an hour, knowing that we were expecting him.'

'He expected, you will remember, to be here on the fifth.'

'And here we are at the ninth. This evening the margin of possible delay expires.'

'What do you think should be done,' asked Athos, 'if we have no news of them to-night?'

'*Pardieu!* we must go and look for them.'

'All right,' said Athos.

'But Raoul?' said Aramis.

Chapter LXXVIII

The Battle of Charenton

As Athos and Aramis proceeded, and passed different companies on the road, they became aware that they were arriving near the field of battle.

'Ah! my friend!' cried Athos, suddenly, 'where have you brought us? I fancy I perceive around us faces of different officers in the royal army; is not that the Duc de Châtillon himself coming toward us with his brigadiers?'

'Good-day, sirs,' said the duke, advancing; 'you are puzzled by what you see here, but one word will explain everything. There is now a truce and a conference. The prince, Monsieur de Retz, the Duc de Beaufort, the Duc de Bouillon, are talking over public affairs. Now one of two things must happen: either matters will not be arranged, or they will be arranged, in which last case I shall be relieved of my command and we shall still meet again.'

'Sir,' said Aramis, 'you speak to the point. Allow me to ask you a question: Where are the plenipotentiaries?'

'At Charenton, in the second house on the right on entering from the direction of Paris.'

'And was this conference arranged beforehand?'

'No, gentlemen, it seems to be the result of certain propositions which Mazarin made last night to the Parisians.'

Athos and Aramis exchanged smiles; for they well knew what those propositions were, to whom they had been made and who had made them.

'And that house in which the plenipotentiaries are,' asked Athos, 'belongs to— '

'To Monsieur de Chanleu, who commands your troops at Charenton. I say your troops, for I presume that you gentlemen are Frondeurs?'

'Yes, almost,' said Aramis.

'We are for the king and the princes,' added Athos.

'We must understand each other,' said the duke. 'The king is with us and his generals are the Duke of Orléans and the Prince de Condé, although I must add 'tis almost impossible now to know to which party any one belongs.'

'Yes,' answered Athos, 'but his right place is in our ranks, with the Prince de Conti, De Beaufort, D'Elbeuf, and De Bouillon; but, sir, supposing that the conference is broken off—are you going to try to take Charenton?'

'Such are my orders.'

'Sir, since you command the cavalry— '

'Pardon me, I am commander-in-chief.'

'So much the better. You must know all your officers—I mean those more distinguished.'

'Why, yes, very nearly.'

'Will you then kindly tell me if you have in your command the Chevalier d'Artagnan, lieutenant in the musketeers?'

'No, sir, he is not with us; he left Paris more than six weeks ago and is believed to have gone on a mission to England.'

'I knew that, but I supposed he had returned.'

'No, sir; no one has seen him. I can answer positively on that point, for the musketeers belong to our forces and Monsieur de Cambon, the substitute for Monsieur d'Artagnan, still holds his place.'

The two friends looked at each other.

'You see,' said Athos.

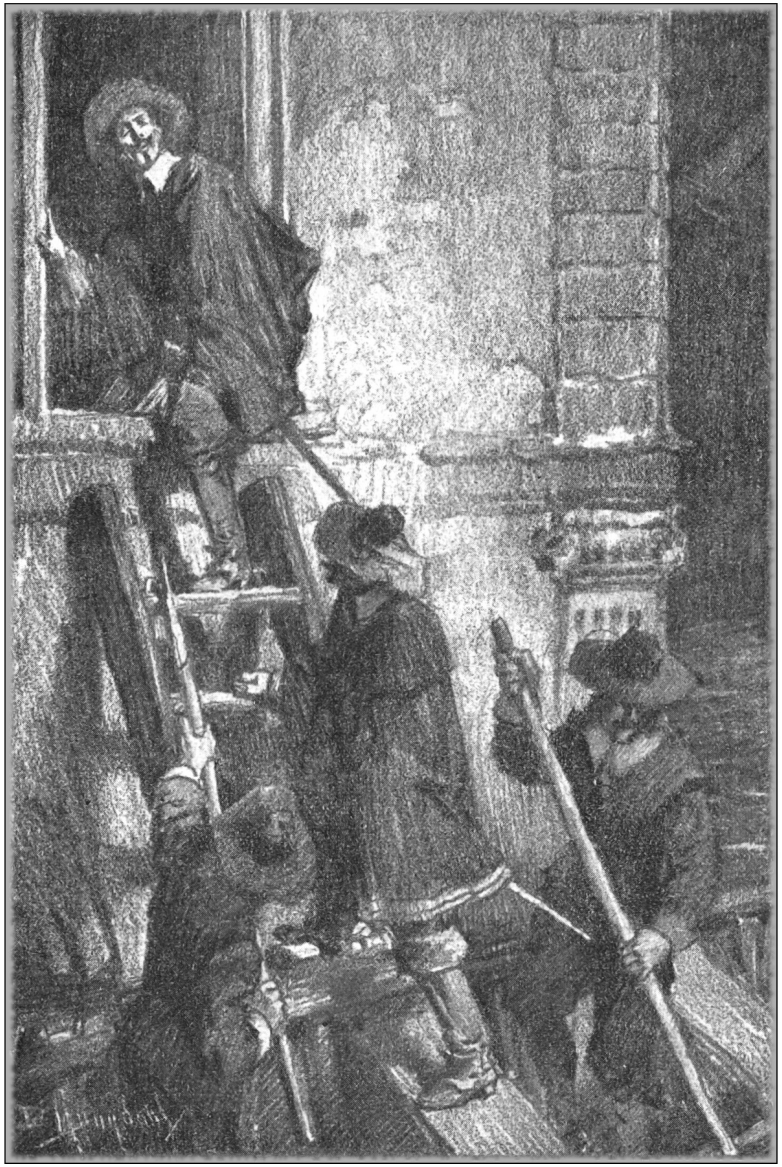
'It is strange,' said Aramis.

'It is absolutely certain that some misfortune has happened to them on the way.'

'If we have no news of them this evening, to-morrow we must start.'

Athos nodded affirmatively, then turning:

'And Monsieur de Bragelonne, a young man fifteen years of age, attached to the Prince de Condé—has he the honour of being known to you?' diffident in allowing the sarcastic Aramis to perceive how strong were his paternal feelings.



Instead of entering by the doors, people entered by the windows

'Wait a little, Aramis; it will be time for you to perceive my motive when we have paid our visit to the coadjutor.'

'Let us then go to the archiepiscopal palace,' said Aramis.

They directed their horses to the city. On arriving at the cradle from which Paris sprang they found it inundated with water, and it was again necessary to take a boat. The palace rose from the bosom of the water, and to see the number of boats around it one would have fancied one's self not in Paris, but in Venice. Some of these boats were dark and mysterious, others noisy and lighted up with torches. The friends slid in through this congestion of embarkation and landed in their turn. The palace was surrounded with water, but a kind of staircase had been fixed to the lower walls; and the only difference was, that instead of entering by the doors, people entered by the windows.

Thus did Athos and Aramis make their appearance in the ante-chamber, where about a dozen noblemen were collected in waiting.

'Good heavens!' said Aramis to Athos, 'does the coadjutor intend to indulge himself in the pleasure of making us cool our hearts off in his ante-chamber?'

'My dear friend, we must take people as we find them. The coadjutor is at this moment one of the seven kings of Paris, and has a court. Let us send in our names, and if he does not send us a suitable message we will leave him to his own affairs or those of France. Let us call one of these lackeys, with a demi-pistole in the left hand.'

'Exactly so,' cried Aramis. 'Ah! if I'm not mistaken here's Bazin. Come here, fellow.'

Bazin, who was crossing the ante-chamber majestically in his clerical dress, turned around to see who the impertinent gentleman was who thus addressed him; but seeing his friends he went up to them quickly and expressed delight at seeing them.

'A truce to compliments,' said Aramis; 'we want to see the coadjutor, and instantly, as we are in haste.'

'Certainly, sir—it is not such lords as you are who are allowed to wait in the ante-chamber, only just now he has a secret conference with Monsieur de Bruy.'

'De Bruy!' cried the friends, ''tis then useless our seeing monsieur the coadjutor this evening,' said Aramis, 'so we give it up.'

'Yes, surely, he came with the prince; a charming young man; he is one of your friends then, monsieur le comte?'

'Yes, sir,' answered Athos, agitated; 'so much so that I wish to see him if possible.'

'Quite possible, sir; do me the favour to accompany me and I will conduct you to headquarters.'

'Halloo, there!' cried Aramis, turning around; 'what a noise behind us!'

'A body of cavaliers is coming toward us,' said Châtillon.

'I recognise the coadjutor by his Frondist hat.'

'And I the Duc de Beaufort by his white plume of ostrich feathers.'

'They are coming, full gallop; the prince is with them—ah! he is leaving them!'

'They are beating the rappel!' cried Châtillon; 'we must discover what is going on.'

In fact, they saw the soldiers running to their arms; the trumpets sounded; the drums beat; the Duc de Beaufort drew his sword. On his side the prince sounded a rappel and all the officers of the royalist army, mingling momentarily with the Parisian troops, ran to him.

'Gentlemen,' cried Châtillon, 'the truce is broken, that is evident; they are going to fight; go, then, into Charenton, for I shall begin in a short time—there's a signal from the prince!'

The cornet of a troop had in fact just raised the standard of the prince.

'Farewell, till the next time we meet,' cried Châtillon, and he set off, full gallop.

Athos and Aramis turned also and went to salute the coadjutor and the Duc de Beaufort. As to the Duc de Bouillon, he had such a fit of gout as obliged him to return to Paris in a litter; but his place was well filled by the Duc d'Elbeuf and his four sons, ranged around him like a staff. Meantime, between Charenton and the royal army was left a space which looked ready to serve as a last resting place for the dead.

'Gentlemen,' cried the coadjutor, tightening his sash, which he wore, after the fashion of the ancient military prelates, over his archiepiscopal simar, 'there's the enemy approaching. Let us save them half of their journey.'

And without caring whether he were followed or not he set off; his regiment, which bore the name of the regiment of Corinth, from the name of his

archbishopric, darted after him and began the fight. Monsieur de Beaufort sent his cavalry, toward Etampes and Monsieur de Chanleu, who defended the place, was ready to resist an assault, or if the enemy were repulsed, to attempt a sortie.

The battle soon became general and the coadjutor performed miracles of valor. His proper vocation had always been the sword and he was delighted whenever he could draw it from the scabbard, no matter for whom or against whom.

Chanleu, whose fire at one time repulsed the royal regiment, thought that the moment was come to pursue it; but it was reformed and led again to the charge by the Duc de Châtillon in person. This charge was so fierce, so skilfully conducted, that Chanleu was almost surrounded. He commanded a retreat, which began, step by step, foot by foot; unhappily, in an instant he fell, mortally wounded. De Châtillon saw him fall and announced it in a loud voice to his men, which raised their spirits and completely disheartened their enemies, so that every man thought only of his own safety and tried to gain the trenches, where the coadjutor was trying to reform his disorganised regiment.

Suddenly a squadron of cavalry galloped up to encounter the royal troops, who were entering, *pêle-mêle*, the intrenchments with the fugitives. Athos and Aramis charged at the head of their squadrons; Aramis with sword and pistol in his hands, Athos with his sword in his scabbard, his pistol in his saddle-bags; calm and cool as if on the parade, except that his noble and beautiful countenance became sad as he saw slaughtered so many men who were sacrificed on the one side to the obstinacy of royalty and on the other to the personal rancour of the princes. Aramis, on the contrary, struck right and left and was almost delirious with excitement. His bright eyes kindled, and his mouth, so finely formed, assumed a wicked smile; every blow he aimed was sure, and his pistol finished the deed—annihilated the wounded wretch who tried to rise again.

On the opposite side two cavaliers, one covered with a gilt cuirass, the other wearing simply a buff doublet, from which fell the sleeves of a vest of blue velvet, charged in front. The cavalier in the gilt cuirass fell upon Aramis and struck a blow that Aramis parried with his wonted skill.

'Ah! 'tis you, Monsieur de Châtillon,' cried the chevalier; 'welcome to you—I expected you.'

'Ah!' he cried, 'by Jove! you're welcome, sirs. You are coming to sup with me, are you not? Boisgoli, tell Noirmont that I have two guests. You know Noirmont, do you not? The successor of Father Marteau who makes the excellent pies you know of. Boisgoli, let him send one of his best, but not such a one as he made for La Ramée. Thank God! we don't want either rope ladders or gag-pears *now*.'

'My lord,' said Athos, 'do not let us disturb you. We came merely to inquire after your health and to take your orders.'

'As to my health, since it has stood five years of prison, with Monsieur de Chavigny to boot, 'tis excellent! As to my orders, since every one gives his own commands in our party, I shall end, if this goes on, by giving none at all.'

'In short, my lord,' said Athos, glancing at Aramis, 'your highness is discontented with your party?'

'Discontented, sir! say my highness is furious! To such a degree, I assure you, though I would not say so to others, that if the queen, acknowledging the injuries she has done me, would recall my mother and give me the reversion of the admiralty, which belonged to my father and was promised me at his death, well! it would not be long before I should be training dogs to say that there were greater traitors in France than the Cardinal Mazarin!'

At this Athos and Aramis could not help exchanging not only a look but a smile; and had they not known it for a fact, this would have told them that De Châtillon and De Flamarens had been there.

'My lord,' said Athos, 'we are satisfied; we came here only to express our loyalty and to say that we are at your lordship's service and his most faithful servants.'

'My most faithful friends, gentlemen, my most faithful friends; you have proved it. And if ever I am reconciled with the court I shall prove to you, I hope, that I remain your friend, as well as that of—what the devil are their names—D'Artagnan and Porthos?'

'D'Artagnan and Porthos.'

'Ah, yes. You understand, then, Comte de la Fère, you understand, Chevalier d'Herblay, that I am altogether and always at your service.'

Athos and Aramis bowed and went out.

'My dear Athos,' cried Aramis, 'I think you consented to accompany me only to give me a lesson—God forgive me!'

'You did well; you would have caused him an access of his disease. Let us go to Monsieur de Beaufort.'

The two friends went to the Hôtel de Vendôme. It was ten o'clock when they arrived. The Hôtel de Vendôme was not less guarded than the Hôtel de Bouillon, and presented as warlike an appearance. There were sentinels, a guard in the court, stacks of arms, and horses saddled. Two horsemen going out as Athos and Aramis entered were obliged to give place to them.

'Ah! ah! gentlemen,' said Aramis, 'decidedly it is a night for meetings. We shall be very unfortunate if, after meeting so often this evening, we should not succeed in meeting to-morrow.'

'Oh, as to that, sir,' replied Châtillon (for it was he who, with Flamarens, was leaving the Duc de Beaufort), 'you may be assured; for if we meet by night without seeking each other, much more shall we meet by day when wishing it.'

'I hope that is true,' said Aramis.

'As for me, I am sure of it,' said the duke.

De Flamarens and De Châtillon continued on their way and Athos and Aramis dismounted.

Hardly had they given the bridles of their horses to their lackeys and rid themselves of their cloaks when a man approached them, and after looking at them for an instant by the doubtful light of the lantern hung in the centre of the courtyard he uttered an exclamation of joy and ran to embrace them.

'Comte de la Fère!' the man cried out; 'Chevalier d'Herblay! How does it happen that you are in Paris?'

'Rochefort!' cried the two friends.

'Yes! we arrived four or five days ago from the Vendômois, as you know, and we are going to give Mazarin something to do. You are still with us, I presume?'

'More than ever. And the duke?'

'Furious against the cardinal. You know his success—our dear duke? He is really king of Paris; he can't go out without being mobbed by his admirers.'

'Ah! so much the better! Can we have the honour of seeing his highness?'

'I shall be proud to present you,' and Rochefort walked on. Every door was opened to him. Monsieur de Beaufort was at supper, but he rose quickly on hearing the two friends announced.

'I hope I have not made you wait too long, sir,' said the duke; 'at all events, here I am.'

'Monsieur de Châtillon,' cried Aramis, taking from his saddle-bags a second pistol, 'I think if your pistols have been discharged you are a dead man.'

'Thank God, sir, they are not!'

And the duke, pointing his pistol at Aramis, fired. But Aramis bent his head the instant he saw the duke's finger press the trigger and the ball passed without touching him.

'Oh! you've missed me,' cried Aramis, 'but I swear to Heaven! I will not miss you.'

'If I give you time!' cried the duke, spurring on his horse and rushing upon him with his drawn sword.

Aramis awaited him with that terrible smile which was peculiar to him on such occasions, and Athos, who saw the duke advancing toward Aramis with the rapidity of lightning, was just going to cry out, 'Fire! fire, then!' when the shot was fired. De Châtillon opened his arms and fell back on the crupper of his horse.

The ball had entered his breast through a notch in the cuirass.

'I am a dead man,' he said, and fell from his horse to the ground.

'I told you this, I am now grieved I have kept my word. Can I be of any use to you?'

Châtillon made a sign with his hand and Aramis was about to dismount when he received a violent shock; 'twas a thrust from a sword, but his cuirass turned aside the blow.

He turned around and seized his new antagonist by the wrist, when he started back, exclaiming, 'Raoul!'

'Raoul?' cried Athos.

The young man recognised at the same instant the voices of his father and the Chevalier d'Herblay; two officers in the Parisian forces rushed at that instant on Raoul, but Aramis protected him with his sword.

'My prisoner!' he cried.

Athos took his son's horse by the bridle and led him forth out of the *mêlée*.

At this crisis of the battle, the prince, who had been seconding De Châtillon in the second line, appeared in the midst of the fight; his eagle eye made him known and his blows proclaimed the hero.

On seeing him, the regiment of Corinth, which the coadjutor had not been able to reorganize in spite of all his efforts, threw itself into the midst of the Parisian forces, put them into confusion and re-entered Charenton flying. The coadjutor, dragged along with his fugitive forces, passed near the group formed by Athos, Raoul and Aramis. Aramis could not in his jealousy avoid being pleased at the coadjutor's misfortune, and was about to utter some *bon mot* more witty than correct, when Athos stopped him.

'On, on!' he cried, 'this is no moment for compliments; or rather, back, for the battle seems to be lost by the Frondeurs.'

'It is a matter of indifference to me,' said Aramis; 'I came here only to meet De Châtillon; I have met him, I am contented; 'tis something to have met De Châtillon in a duel!'

'And besides, we have a prisoner,' said Athos, pointing to Raoul.

The three cavaliers continued their road on full gallop.

'What were you doing in the battle, my friend?' inquired Athos of the youth; ''twas not your right place, I think, as you were not equipped for an engagement!'

'I had no intention of fighting to-day, sir; I was charged, indeed, with a mission to the cardinal and had set out for Rueil, when, seeing Monsieur de Châtillon charge, an invincible desire possessed me to charge at his side. It was then that he told me two cavaliers of the Parisian army were seeking me and named the Comte de la Fère.'

'What! you knew we were there and yet wished to kill your friend the chevalier?'

'I did not recognise the chevalier in armour, sir!' said Raoul, blushing; 'though I might have known him by his skill and coolness in danger.'

'Thank you for the compliment, my young friend,' replied Aramis, 'we can see from whom you learned courtesy. Then you were going to Rueil?'

'Yes! I have a despatch from the prince to his eminence.'

'You must still deliver it,' said Athos.

'No false generosity, count! the fate of our friends, to say nothing of our own, is perhaps in that very despatch.'

'This young man must not, however, fail in his duty,' said Athos.

'My lord,' said Athos, 'we admire your devotion to the cause you have espoused, in remaining at the head of the army whilst so ill, in so much pain.'

'One must,' replied Monsieur de Bouillon, 'sacrifice one's comfort to the public good; but I confess to you I am now almost exhausted. My spirit is willing, my head is clear, but this demon, the gout, o'ercrows me. I confess, if the court would do justice to my claims and give the head of my house the title of prince, and if my brother De Turenne were reinstated in his command I would return to my estates and leave the court and parliament to settle things between themselves as they might.'

'You are perfectly right, my lord.'

'You think so? At this very moment the court is making overtures to me; hitherto I have repulsed them; but since such men as you assure me that I am wrong in doing so, I've a good mind to follow your advice and to accept a proposition made to me by the Duc de Châtillon just now.'

'Accept it, my lord, accept it,' said Aramis.

'Faith! yes. I am even sorry that this evening I almost repulsed—but there will be a conference to-morrow and we shall see.'

The two friends saluted the duke.

'Go, gentlemen,' he said; 'you must be much fatigued after your voyage. Poor King Charles! But, after all, he was somewhat to blame in all that business and we may console ourselves with the reflection that France has no cause of reproach in the matter and did all she could to serve him.'

'Oh! as to that,' said Aramis, 'we are witnesses. Mazarin especially— '

'Yes, do you know, I am very glad to hear you give that testimony; the cardinal has some good in him, and if he were not a foreigner—well, he would be more justly estimated. Oh! the devil take this gout!'

Athos and Aramis took their leave, but even in the ante-chamber they could still hear the duke's cries; he was evidently suffering the tortures of the damned.

When they reached the street, Aramis said:

'Well, Athos, what do you think?'

'Of whom?'

'*Pardieu!* of Monsieur de Bouillon.'

'My friend, I think that he is much troubled with gout.'

'You noticed that I didn't breathe a word as to the purpose of our visit?'

'How the devil do they venture so near the Hôtel de Bouillon?'

Athos smiled, but did not reply. Five minutes afterward they knocked at the prince's door.

This door was guarded by a sentinel and there was also a guard placed in the courtyard, ready to obey the orders of the Prince de Conti's lieutenant.

Monsieur de Bouillon had the gout, but notwithstanding his illness, which had prevented his mounting on horseback for the last month—-that is, since Paris had been besieged—he was ready to receive the Comte de la Fère and the Chevalier d'Herblay.

He was in bed, but surrounded with all the paraphernalia of war. Everywhere were swords, pistols, cuirasses, and arquebuses, and it was plain that as soon as his gout was better Monsieur de Bouillon would give a pretty tangle to the enemies of the parliament to unravel. Meanwhile, to his great regret, as he said, he was obliged to keep his bed.

'Ah, gentlemen,' he cried, as the two friends entered, 'you are very happy! you can ride, you can go and come and fight for the cause of the people. But I, as you see, am nailed to my bed—ah! this demon, gout—this demon, gout!'

'My lord,' said Athos, 'we are just arrived from England and our first concern is to inquire after your health.'

'Thanks, gentlemen, thanks! As you see, my health is but indifferent. But you come from England. And King Charles is well, as I have just heard?'

'He is dead, my lord!' said Aramis.

'Pooh!' said the duke, too much astonished to believe it true.

'Dead on the scaffold; condemned by parliament.'

'Impossible!'

'And executed in our presence.'

'What, then, has Monsieur de Flamarens been telling me?'

'Monsieur de Flamarens?'

'Yes, he has just gone out.'

Athos smiled. 'With two companions?' he said.

'With two companions, yes,' replied the duke. Then he added with a certain uneasiness, 'Did you meet them?'

'Why, yes, I think so—in the street,' said Athos; and he looked smilingly at Aramis, who looked at him with an expression of surprise.

'The devil take this gout!' cried Monsieur de Bouillon, evidently ill at ease.

'In the first place, count, this youth is our prisoner; you seem to forget that. What I propose to do is fair in war; the vanquished must not be dainty in the choice of means. Give me the despatch, Raoul.'

The young man hesitated and looked at Athos as if seeking to read in his eyes a rule of conduct.

'Give him the despatch, Raoul! you are the chevalier's prisoner.'

Raoul gave it up reluctantly; Aramis instantly seized and read it.

'You,' he said, 'you, who are so trusting, read and reflect that there is something in this letter important for us to see.'

Athos took the letter, frowning, but an idea that he should find something in this letter about D'Artagnan conquered his unwillingness to read it.

'My lord, I shall send this evening to your eminence in order to reinforce the troop of Monsieur de Comminges, the ten men you demand. They are good soldiers, fit to confront the two violent adversaries whose address and resolution your eminence is fearful of.'

'Oh!' cried Athos.

'Well,' said Aramis, 'what think you about these two enemies whom it requires, besides Comminges's troop, ten good soldiers to confront; are they not as like as two drops of water to D'Artagnan and Porthos?'

'We'll search Paris all day long,' said Athos, 'and if we have no news this evening we will return to the road to Picardy; and I feel no doubt that, thanks to D'Artagnan's ready invention, we shall then find some clew which will solve our doubts.'

'Yes, let us search Paris and especially inquire of Planchet if he has yet heard from his former master.'

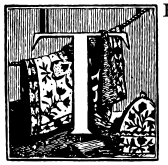
'That poor Planchet! You speak of him very much at your ease, Aramis; he has probably been killed. All those fighting citizens went out to battle and they have been massacred.'

It was, then, with a sentiment of uneasiness whether Planchet, who alone could give them information, was alive or dead, that the friends returned to the Place Royale; to their great surprise they found the citizens still encamped there, drinking and bantering each other, although, doubtless, mourned by their families, who thought they were at Charenton in the thickest of the fighting.

Athos and Aramis again questioned Planchet, but he had seen nothing of D'Artagnan; they wished to take Planchet with them, but he could not leave his troop, who at five o'clock returned home, saying that they were returning from the battle, whereas they had never lost sight of the bronze equestrian statue of Louis XIII.

Chapter LXXVII

The three Lieutenants of the Generalissimo



THE night was dark, but still the town resounded with those noises that disclose a city in a state of siege. Athos and Aramis did not proceed a hundred steps without being stopped by sentinels placed before the barricades, who demanded the watchword; and on their saying that they were going to Monsieur de Bouillon on a mission of importance a guide was given them under pretext of conducting them, but in fact as a spy over their movements.

On arriving at the Hôtel de Bouillon they came across a little troop of three cavaliers, who seemed to know every possible password; for they walked without either guide or escort, and on arriving at the barricades had nothing to do but to speak to those who guarded them, who instantly let them pass with evident deference, due probably to their high birth.

On seeing them Athos and Aramis stood still.

'Oh!' cried Aramis, 'do you see, count?'

'Yes,' said Athos.

'Who do these three cavaliers appear to you to be?'

'What do you think, Aramis?'

'Why, they are our men.'

'You are not mistaken; I recognise Monsieur de Flamarens.'

'And I, Monsieur de Châtillon.'

'As to the cavalier in the brown cloak— '

'It is the cardinal.'

'In person.'